Sikhs, but was surrounded by Muslim-majority areas. There were other factors to be considered as well. In Bengal, Calcutta was the main industrial cluster and had a Hindu majority. However, the raw jute for its jute mills came from the Muslim-majority east. In Punjab, critical irrigation systems had to be severed. The barrister would have pondered these issues in the solitude of his bungalow.

Even as Radcliffe was drawing his line, communal violence continued to escalate across the countryside. Refugees were already on the move even before the border had been demarcated. The maps that would decide the fate of millions was delivered to the Viceroy on 13 August, but they were not made public for seventy-two hours. Thus, when India became independent on 15 August, many Indians along the borderlands did not know in which country their homes would fall. The maps were made public a day later and the bloodbath began. People were on the move—on trains, on bullock-carts and on foot—holding on to whatever they could salvage of their former lives. It is estimated that about 7 million Muslims moved from India to Pakistan and a similar Hindu–Sikh population shifted from Pakistan to India. Meanwhile, a disenchanted Radcliffe returned to his London chambers. He returned the 2000 pounds that he had received for his services.

The Hindus and Sikhs who fled West Paksitan were directed to hundreds of refugee camps. One of the largest camps was in Kurukshetra, the battlefield where the Pandavas and Kauravas are said to have fought each other in the Mahabharata. The camp was planned for 100,000, but three times the number came to inhabit it by December 1947.[2] Half a million refugees, mostly from West Punjab, came to Delhi. These desperate people squatted wherever they could, including the pavements of Connaught Circus. In time, they would build homes in ‘colonies’ allotted to them in the south and west of Lutyens’s garden city. We know them today as Lajpat Nagar, Rajendra Nagar, Punjabi Bagh and so on. A smaller group of refugees from East Pakistan also made their way to Delhi and were settled in East Pakistan Displaced Persons Colony. Now renamed Chittaranjan Park, it retains a distinct Bengali identity. Thus, within a few decades, Delhi